

Research Fellowship Program

Master Plan for Reform

Presenter

Son In-chang, Senior Agricultural
Researcher

Date

17 September 2026

CONTENTS

Research System Team, Research Policy Division



Background



Current Status & Issues



Vision & Strategy



Detailed Action Plans



Implementation Timeline



Expected Outcomes

01. Background

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

The Research Fellowship Program

Provides scientists holding a master's or doctoral degree, from Korea or abroad, with the opportunity to develop their expertise at the RDA and its affiliated institutes



RDA	2 fellows Post-MS 2
NICS	55 fellows Post-doc 25 · Post-MS 3
NIAS	39 fellows Post-doc 27 · Post-MS 12

NAAS	136 fellows Post-doc 99 · Post-MS 37
NIHHS	44 fellows Post-doc 42 · Post-MS 2

Authorized 264 / Actual 276 (as of Aug. 2026)

01. Background

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

Why reform is needed

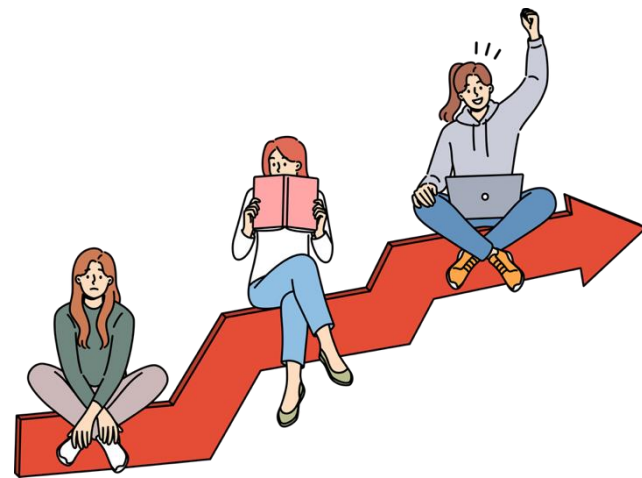
- Research Fellows are core personnel driving agricultural R&D results
- The current system manages fellows around individual projects
- Limited research continuity and inequitable compensation
- No clear standards for career growth support or rights protection

Shift to talent
development

Rights protection

01. Background

Research System Team, Research Policy Division



Better allowance 70.3%

· Raising the training allowance was the most frequent request

“We need better working conditions”



Skills development 61.9%

· Capacity building 61.9%, career development support 61.3%

“We want more training opportunities”



Contract stability 35.1%

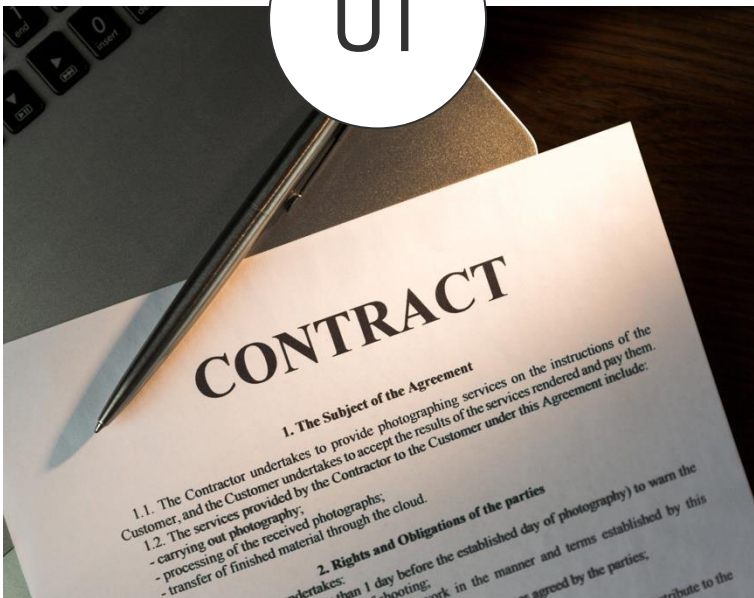
· Allowance and annual leave reset upon re-hiring after contract end

“Service rules need to be improved”

02. Current Status & Issues

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

01



Contract discontinuity & reset conditions

- Re-posting and re-hiring at the end of every project
- Allowance, annual leave and other conditions reset to zero

02



Uneven compensation Varies by institute

- Allowance ceiling frozen since 2021
- Starting pay and annual increments differ across institutes

03



Evaluation system Limited qualitative view

- Heavy weighting on short-term quantitative output
- Research process and ambition of goals are under-assessed

04



Rights protection Regulatory blind spot

- No standards on scope of duties or prohibited unfair treatment
- Grievance procedures are not clearly communicated

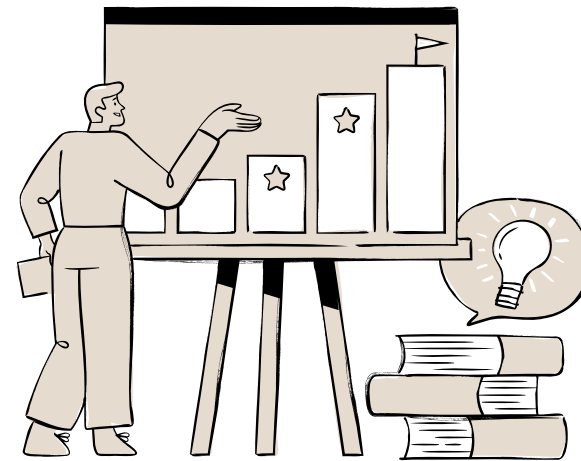
03. Vision & Strategy

Research System Team, Research Policy Division



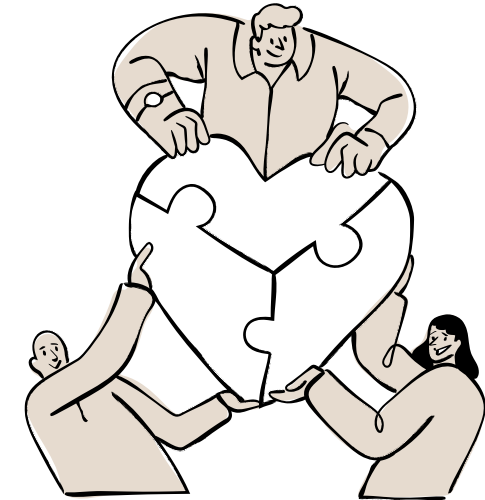
STABILITY

- Move to a medium- to long-term contract system
- Tighter management of projects and scope of duties
- Staffing system that minimises research gaps



GROWTH

- Strengthen tailored training and career development support
- Raise allowance levels and unify payment standards
- Evaluation and recognition centred on ambition and growth



PROTECTION

- Rights protection rules and a grievance response system
- Preventive workplace management and field communication

03. Vision & Strategy

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

Project execution focused	VS	Talent development focused
Project-based contracts	Contract	Position-based, up to 10 years (post-doc)
Short-term output focus	Growth	IDP · capacity building · qualitative growth
Gaps between institutes	Reward	Unified standards, higher ceiling
No basis in the regulations	Protection	New rights protection provisions

04. Action Plans

Strategy 1

Building a stable foundation for research

1-1. Shift to a medium- to long-term contract system

Securing continuity in both research and conditions

Postdoctoral Fellows



“Project-based contracts” → “Position-based contracts”

	CURRENT	REFORMED
Basis	Until the project ends	The research position held (up to 10 years)
Continuity	Contract ends with the project	Same position continues after project ends
Conditions	Allowance and leave reset	Working conditions carry over

Under the Act on the Protection of Fixed-Term Employees, doctorate holders are exempt from the fixed-term use period

04. Action Plans

Strategy 1

Building a stable foundation for research

1-1. Shift to a medium- to long-term contract system Securing continuity in both research and conditions

Post-Master's Fellows



Term

Project-based contracts are retained, but the current cap of 3 years is extended to the end of the project

Under the Fixed-Term Employees Act, where a period is set for completing specific work, the contract may run until that work ends

Growth

Linked to in-house talent programs so fellows can move on to doctoral study, research officer posts and other next career steps

Guidance on joint academia-research degree programs, research officer recruitment, and job and skills training

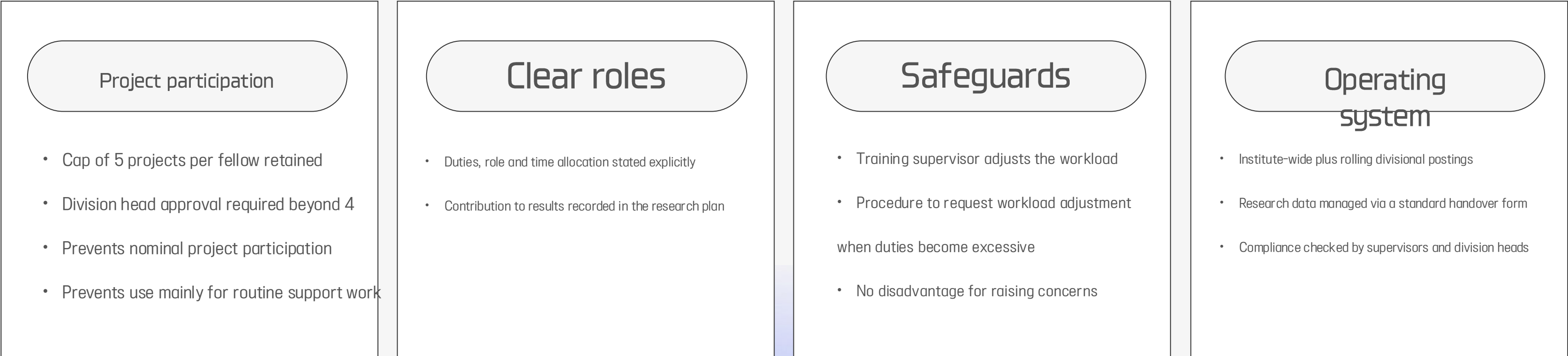
04. Action Plans

Strategy 1

Building a stable foundation for research

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

1-2. Tighter management of project participation and scope of duties



Keeping collaborative research flexible while clarifying roles and scope of duties, so that nominal participation and the offloading of non-research work are prevented

04. Action Plans

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

[Strategy 2] Growth-centred capacity building and reward system

- Connects onboarding, skills development and career design
- Fellows design their own path; supervisors support it

✓ (Training) Regular onboarding and core job training

✓ (Growth) Shared growth and career development support

✓ (Evaluation) More qualitative indicators in performance review

✓ (Reward) Official recognition of excellence and more career incentives

✓ (Allowance) Inflation-adjusted levels, standardised across institutes

04. Action Plans

Strategy 2

Growth-centred capacity building and reward system

2-1. Stronger training and career support, reformed evaluation and rewards

Training

- Regular onboarding and research engagement training (twice a year)
- More hands-on skills training
- * AI, statistics, programming, etc.

Growth

- Workshops held
- Individual Development Plan (IDP) introduced for setting personal skill and career goals

Evaluation system

- Comprehensive review of ambition, research process and qualitative contribution (goal attainment score abolished)
- External members join the review panel to ensure fairness

Recognition

- New Administrator's Award
- Formally recorded as career credit
- More career-development rewards

A support system that lets fellows grow on their own terms, with evaluation shifted toward ambition and quality

04. Action Plans

Strategy 2

Growth-centred capacity building and reward system

Current evaluation	Reformed	Growth-centred evaluation
Diligence in project work 20 pts	Diligence	Diligence in project work 20 pts
Goal attainment 30 pts	Key criterion	Ambitious research design 30 pts
Research output 50 pts	Research output	Research output 50 pts
Varies by institute; absent in some	Awards	New Administrator's Award; counts as career credit

04. Action Plans

Strategy 2

Growth-centred capacity building and reward system

2-2. Realistic allowance levels and unified payment standards

- The allowance, frozen since 2021, is raised in line with inflation
- Payment standards that differed by institute are unified

4.5
M KRW

Monthly ceiling, post-doc

Up 13.7% from the current KRW 3.9M, reflecting inflation and the research labour market

5
grades

Starting pay grades unified

The 4-9 grades used across institutes are unified into 5: post-doc KRW 2.8-3.4M, post-MS KRW 2.4-2.6M

3.2
M KRW

Monthly ceiling, post-MS

Raised from the current KRW 2.8M; the floor will rise in stages after talks with budget authorities

0.2
M KRW

Annual increment, top grade

Unified across institutes at KRW 200k (excellent) / 100k (good) / 50k (fair), so the ceiling is reachable even starting at the floor

04. Action Plans

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

[Strategy 3] Rights protection and a culture of mutual respect

- New rights protection basis in the regulations, with prohibited acts written in
- A safety net connecting counselling through to follow-up care



(Rules) Explicit ban on appropriating results, offloading chores, and personal insult



(Accountability) Supervisory duties and response standards for supervisors and division heads



(Procedure) Intake → initial counselling → triage → protective measures → follow-up



(Urgent protection) Interim measures and separation even before an inquiry concludes



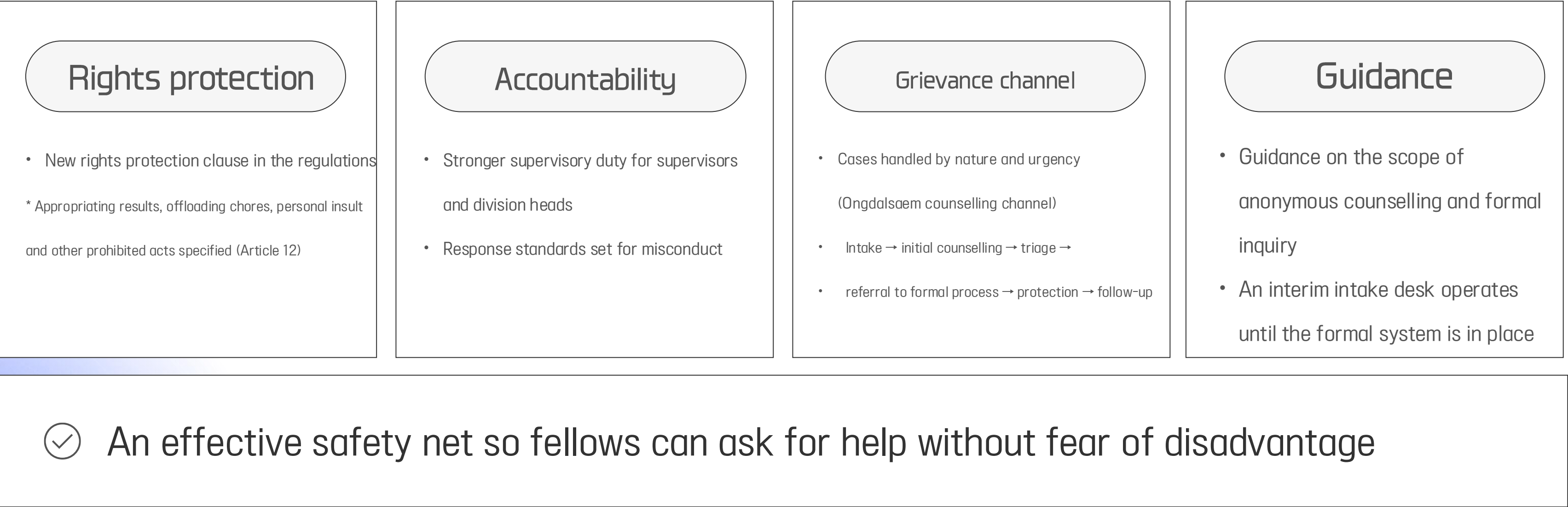
(Prevention) Operating guidelines, workplace surveys and regular open meetings

04. Action Plans

Strategy 3

Rights protection and a culture of mutual respect

3-1. Rights protection rules and a grievance response system

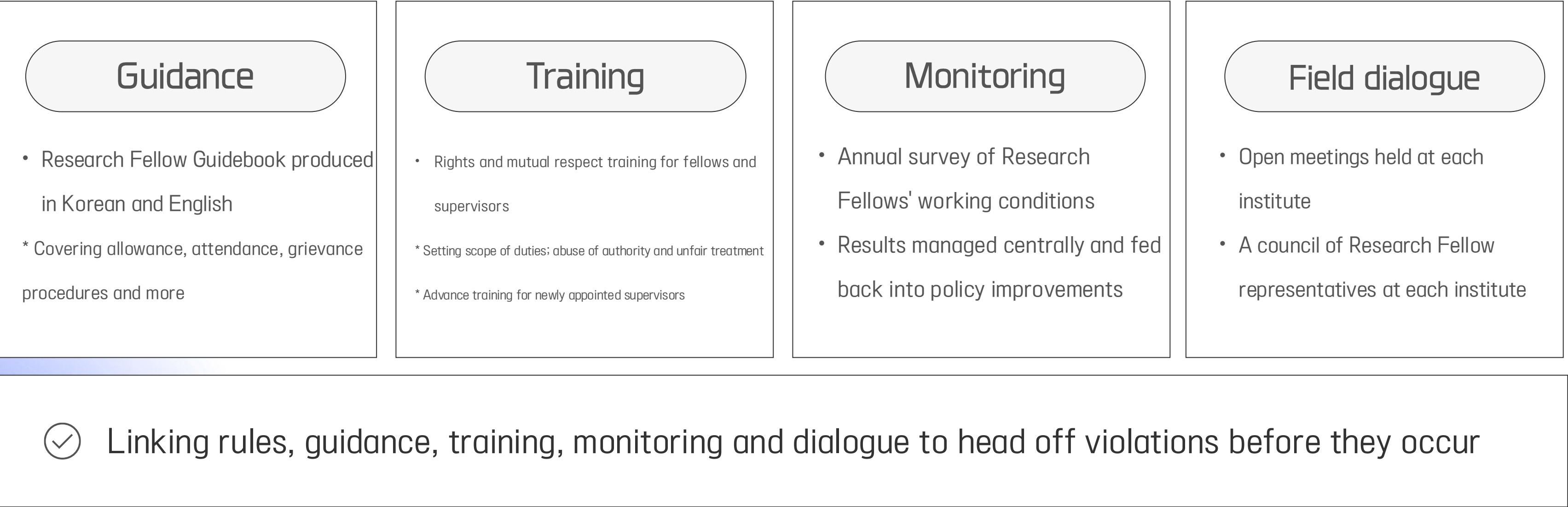


04. Action Plans

Strategy 3

Rights protection and a culture of mutual respect

3-2. Preventive workplace management and stronger field communication



05. Implementation Timeline

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

2nd half of 2026

- > Amend the operating regulations (contracts, allowance, rights)
- > Higher allowance ceiling takes effect immediately
- > Operating guidebook produced and distributed
- > Working-conditions survey and open meetings

2027 onward

- > Full rollout of position-based contracts
- > IDP preparation and mentoring made routine
- > Secure budget to raise the allowance floor
- > Field feedback reflected and refinements continued

Stability · Growth · Protection for Research Fellows

Research System Team, Research Policy Division

Let's build it together

THANK YOU

Presenter

San In-chang, Senior Agricultural Researcher

Head, Research System Team

Contact

Research Policy Division, Research Policy Bureau,
RDA
